

Carne Asada Picada

Order of operations: butcher → marinade → freeze → salsa → cook · the full taco

PORTION	THAW = MARINATE	DICE	FREEZER
450 g bags	overnight, fridge	3⁄8–1⁄2" cross-grain	3+ months

Plan-ahead: butcher → marinade → freeze — build the 450 g bags whenever; the meat marinates through the freeze + thaw, no separate marinate step.	Same-day: make the Part 3 salsa (or up to a week ahead — it improves overnight), thaw a bag overnight, then sear ripping hot. Lime, flaky salt, raw onion + cilantro at the plate.
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PART 1MARINADE FORMULA

% of beef wt · per full ~24 lb (11 kg) clod — weigh yours, multiply

Beef shoulder clod diced 3⁄8–1⁄2", across grain	100%	11 kg
Granulated garlic background	0.5%	55 g
White onion rough chunks, to blend	4%	440 g
Maggi seasoning Jugo — umami backbone	2%	220 g
Neutral or olive oil	3%	330 g
Cumin, ground whisper of warmth	0.2%	22 g
Mexican oregano background	0.3%	33 g
Salt Diamond Crystal — with Maggi, ~1% total sodium	0.6%	66 g

No acid & no heat in the bag — on purpose. Over the **season** → **freeze** → **thaw** cycle, lime would sit on the beef the whole slow thaw and bully the flavor (and soften lean beef). So it's seasoned **light and beef-forward** — garlic, cumin, oregano, Maggi, and onion are **quiet complements, not a spice rack** (the beef and the sear are the star) — and you bring brightness + heat **at the taco: fresh lime, flaky salt, and the Part 3 salsa**. **~1% total sodium** (salt 0.6% + Maggi's ~0.4%) — light by design; add at the plate, you can't subtract. Diamond Crystal; Morton = 60%, table = 50%.

Make the Bags

PART 2 BUTCHER → MARINADE → FREEZE

build ahead — the freeze + thaw does the marinating

- 1

Butcher / dice: trim the shoulder clod and cut $\frac{3}{8}$ – $\frac{1}{2}$ " (1–1.5 cm) cubes across the grain — uniform for even searing, cross-grain for tenderness.
- 2

Blend the marinade: everything except the beef into a blender — blend smooth (a splash of water to get it moving if needed). No grating; it scales clean and coats evenly for bulk.
- 3

Combine: toss the diced beef in the blended marinade until every piece is coated — a large tub / bus tub for a full clod.
- 4

Portion + freeze: into quart bags (450 g each), press flat, remove air, label with the date, freeze **right away** — **no separate marinate step**.

The freeze is the marinate. Coat, bag, and freeze right away — the meat seasons as it freezes and again as it thaws overnight, so no separate marinate step is needed. Because there's **no acid in the bag**, the long slow thaw can't turn lean beef to mush — a full thaw is safe and even desirable. The bloomed-in beef-forward seasoning leans on this time to drive flavor; that's why it's built ahead.

PREP TARGETS

this stage — the bags

Dice	$\frac{3}{8}$ – $\frac{1}{2}$ " (1–1.5 cm), across the grain — uniform so it sears evenly, cross-grain so it eats tender.
Marinade	Blended smooth, coats the meat — not watery. A splash of water only to get the blender moving.
Bag + freeze	450 g per quart bag, pressed flat, air out, dated. Freeze immediately; keeps 3+ months.

Asada Salsa

Fried guajillo-pasilla-árbol salsa on a tomatillo-verde base — the only heat at the table

YIELD	ACTIVE	HEAT	KEEPS
~2 cups (480 ml)	~40 min	Hot	1 week, fridge

PART 3

INGREDIENTS

dried chiles + a canned verde base — upgraded by frying

Guajillo chiles stemmed, seeded — flavor & body	4
Pasilla chiles stemmed, seeded — dark, raisiny	2
Chiles de árbol stemmed, seeds in — the heat engine	12
Chiltepín chiles tiny wild pods — very hot, sharp flash heat	~4 g
White onion thick slabs, to char	½
Garlic skin on, to char	3 cloves
Embasa salsa verde 7 oz / 200 g each can	2 cans
Lard or neutral oil — to fry the salsa	13 g
Knorr caldo de pollo optional — only if it tastes flat	to taste

METHOD

toast • soak • char • blend • fry • balance

- 1 Toast the chiles.** Fire the Ooni. Toast guajillo + pasilla flat at the **cooler mouth/edge** — not the screaming center, they scorch — **30–45 sec/side** until they puff, darken, and smell nutty; pull the instant they smell toasty (**guajillo turns acrid fast**). Toast the árbol + chiltepín briefly; they're thin/tiny and scorch first. No Ooni? Comal/cast iron over medium (**~350–400°F**). Have hot water ready.
- 2 Soak.** Push all toasted chiles under the hot water; soak **15–20 min** until fully pliable. **SAVE the soaking water** — it's the salsa's liquid and flavor.
- 3 Char the aromatics — on the Ooni.** Char onion slabs and skin-on garlic **near the center, hard** — blistered, blackened, soft inside. That live-fire char is the salsa's **signature**; cast iron or an oven can't match it. Peel the garlic.
- 4 Blend.** Drained chiles, charred onion, peeled garlic, and **both cans of Embasa** into a blender. Add a splash of reserved soaking water to get it moving. Blend smooth — start thick, you can always loosen. Aim for a sauce that **coats a spoon**.
- 5 Fry it — don't skip.** Heat the lard until shimmering (**~325–350°F**). Pour in the salsa (it'll spit — stand back) and fry, stirring, **5–8 min** until it darkens, thickens, and the raw chile edge cooks off. **Single biggest upgrade**; it also fixes the thin volume of canned base.
- 6 Cool, then balance.** Off heat, rest **10 min** — flavors are muddy while screaming hot and resolve as they settle. **No salt, no lime by design.** If it tastes flat, stir in a pinch of Knorr caldo de pollo — nothing more.

Heat dial — built hot. 12 árbol + chiltepín is genuinely hot — it still bites once built into the taco (the árbol lingers, the chiltepín flashes) — and it's the **only heat at the table** (the marinade is heat-free by design). **Push hotter:** bloom extra árbol/chiltepín whole in the lard 30–45 sec until the oil reddens, *before* the salsa goes in. Milder? Drop to **6 árbol / 2 g chiltepín**. • **No salt, no lime — on purpose.** Embasa is salt-forward and frying concentrates it; the verde base is already tart. Fresh lime + flaky salt finish the meat at the plate — don't double up. • **Texture:** keep it **spoonable, not paste** — it has to cling to the crispy diced picada edges; loosen with soaking water if it tightens. • **Make-ahead:** improves overnight as the fried chile rounds out. No cumin/oregano — the meat carries those.

Cook & Build

COOK TARGETS

this stage — the griddle

Griddle surface (IR)	450–500°F	Internal pull temp	130–140°F
Char coverage	15–20%	Final texture	crusty edge, tender

PART 4

COOK FROM FROZEN

ripping-hot griddle — sear, don't steam

- 1 Thaw:** fridge **overnight** — it seasons as it thaws, and with **no acid there's no mush risk**, so a full thaw is fine. **Pat dry** going in for a clean sear.
- 2 Griddle:** cast iron / flat-top ripping hot (**IR 450–500°F**), light oil. **Single layer, don't crowd** — pat surfaces dry going in. Hard sear.
- 3 Chop-and-sear:** add fresh sliced white onion alongside if you like; chop with two spatulas, let it sit **30–60 sec**, toss for crispy edges.
- 4 Finish & build:** pull at **medium, 130–140°F**. Double-stacked tortillas, the seared beef, then **fresh lime, the Part 3 salsa, raw onion + cilantro, flaky salt**. Brightness *and* heat both come on at the table.

TROUBLESHOOTING

PROBLEM	CAUSE	FIX
Tough / chewy	Cut with the grain, or overcooked	Dice across the grain; pull at 130–140°F
No char	Griddle too cool or crowded	Single layer; recover to 450–500°F
Dull, no brightness	No acid in the bag (by design)	Fresh lime + salsa at the table — that's the brightness
Gray, not seared	Wet surface or crowded pan	Pat dry going in; smaller batches; hotter pan
Not spicy enough	Salsa milder than the table wants	Bloom extra árbol/chiltepín in the lard (Part 3)